

When Consuming Replaces Integrating

Information Overload, Attention Fragmentation, and Cognitive Drift

Cognitive Drift Papers — Mechanism Brief #3

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Core Pattern

information expansion → attention fragmentation → weak integration → Cognitive Drift

Modern information systems have made knowledge easier to access than ever before.

News, social media, messaging platforms, podcasts, search engines, recommendation systems, and artificial intelligence create a continuous stream of new material.

The central problem is no longer obtaining information.

It is preserving enough continuity to organize that information into stable mental models.

What Is Actually Changing

Human understanding depends on more than exposure.

Ideas must remain active long enough to be compared, revised, connected, and integrated.

Digital environments increasingly interrupt that process.

Notifications break concentration.

Feeds reward novelty.

Recommendation systems present the next item before the previous one has been fully absorbed.

The result is not less information.

It is less uninterrupted thinking.

A person can therefore remain highly informed while finding it harder to construct a durable model of what they know.

The cognitive system stays active.

The structure linking its contents becomes weaker.

The Hidden Mechanism

Information arrives as fragments.

Each fragment may be accurate.

Each may be useful.

The failure occurs in the relationships among them.

An article becomes a summary.

A summary becomes a post.

A post becomes part of a feed.

The feed directs attention toward another fragment before the first has been integrated.

Over time, cognition becomes optimized for acquisition rather than consolidation.

The mind grows rich in representations and poor in stable structure.

Cognitive Drift

Cognitive Drift occurs when a person continues acquiring information while becoming progressively less able to organize it into coherent mental models.

The individual does not become uninformed.

They may know more facts, encounter more perspectives, and process more material than before.

But knowledge becomes increasingly distributed across disconnected fragments.

The absence of ignorance is not proof of understanding.

Semantic Fidelity

Semantic Fidelity asks whether information preserves the relationships required for understanding as it moves through increasingly compressed formats.

A headline may preserve the event while losing its history.

A short post may preserve the conclusion while losing the assumptions.

An AI summary may preserve the answer while removing uncertainty and disagreement.

The fragments remain meaningful in isolation.

The larger structure begins to disappear.

Reality Drift Interpretation

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, modern information environments are representational systems optimized for access, speed, novelty, and engagement.

These systems make information highly available.

They do not necessarily preserve the conditions required for integration.

Reality Drift begins when the informational environment remains rich, responsive, and productive while the mental models built inside it become increasingly unstable.

The stream remains coherent.

Understanding becomes harder to maintain.

Recognition Questions

- Am I learning, or mainly encountering?
- Can I explain how today's information connects to what I already know?
- Do new inputs clarify an existing model or continually replace one another?
- Am I consuming faster than I can integrate?
- Can I sustain attention long enough for competing ideas to interact?
- Does the information remain when the feed disappears?

Core Principle

Information overload becomes Cognitive Drift when acquisition expands faster than integration.

Attention fragmentation does not merely reduce focus. It weakens the continuity through which coherent mental models are built.

The problem is not that the mind receives too much information. It is that representations arrive faster than meaning can stabilize.